

KEY

Some insects are found the world over, and some survive only in specific habitats and locations. The insects shown in this map are in locations where they are frequently found.

- Insect swarms
- Insect record-breakers

Types of swarms

When insects form a large group that moves as a single unit, it is called a swarm. Insects sometimes migrate in swarms, or they swarm when looking for a new home, a mate, or for food.

Swarming insects

- 1 Asian ladybug**
Swarm through Oregon in the fall, looking for somewhere to hibernate for the winter.
- 2 Army cutworm moths**
Six- to eight-week migration from eastern plains of Colorado to the mountains.
- 3 Monarch butterfly**
The long migration from the northern US to Mexico lasts generations—no one butterfly makes the entire journey.
- 4 Termites**
In New Orleans, Louisiana, termites build colonies by invading people's homes.
- 5 Cicadas**
In the eastern states of the US, cicada swarms have 13- or 17-year cycles. Young cicadas, known as nymphs, mature, mate, and then die.
- 6 Mayflies**
Annual mass hatching from Lake Erie. They mate, reproduce, then die.
- 7 Army ants**
Found in Central and South America, swarms are called "raids" made up of 100,000–2,000,000 adults.
- 8 Africanized bees**
Aggressive hybrid first released in São Paulo, Brazil. Swarm in thousands when forming new colonies.
- 9 Dragonflies**
A single swarm in Argentina in 1991 was estimated to contain 4–6 billion migrating dragonflies.
- 10 Flying ants**
Swarm annually in Britain as part of a mating ritual.
- 11 Driver ants**
Found in central and east Africa, vast swarms kill animals in their path. People who cannot move out of the way, such as the sick or injured, can be killed.

Mayflies

Shortest adult life. Mayflies spend most of their lives as water-living nymphs. They transform into winged adults that live just long enough to mate and lay eggs. The most extreme example is the American sand-burrowing mayfly, whose adult life lasts just a few minutes.

Fairy wasp

Smallest. 0.006 in (0.14 mm) long. Only visible under a powerful microscope.

Rhyniognatha

Earliest. A 400-million-year-old fossil was found in Scotland in 1919. Scientists believe it may have been winged.

Termite queen

Longest life. Can live up to 45 years.

Goliath Beetle

Heaviest larva. Weighs up to 3.5 oz (100 g).

12 Mosquito swarms

In May 2012, immense swarms of mosquitoes hatched from a lake near Mikoltsy, Belarus.

13 Locusts

The largest swarm recorded was in Kenya in 1954. It covered 77 sq miles (200 sq km) and involved an estimated 10 billion locusts.

14 Midges

The midges that form mating swarms start out as underwater larvae in lakes. Once they can fly, they take off and try to find a mate.